



AFRICAN CONNECTIONS
"Your Gateway to Africa"

Welcomes You to **Ethiopia**



inikwani dehina met'ahi (Welcome in Amharic)

Thank you for choosing African Connections to provide comprehensive tour services for your upcoming “Ethiopia & Ghana Return to the Motherland Tour” scheduled for September 6th - 15th 2026 (9 nights/10 days).

African Connections, “AC” is your Gateway to Africa. We have been a leader in African travel for over 20 years and the entire AC Team is preparing for your upcoming visit to Ethiopia and Ghana.

We pride ourselves on delivery of outstanding concierge services and we are happy to assist you and provide you with information you'll need to prepare for your journey.

When you reach Ethiopia and Ghana, we will meet you at the airport when you arrive and assist you throughout your stay in Ethiopia and Ghana.

Our team is knowledgeable and professional and proud to show you the wonders of Ethiopia and Ghana, countries we know so well.

This welcome guide will provide you with information that will be helpful as you make your travel preparations.

Please review this information carefully. We welcome your questions and look forward to seeing you in Ethiopia and Ghana soon!

Your Tour

You should book your tickets so that you depart from the USA on September 5th 2026, with your arrival in Ethiopia on September 6th 2026.

Your tickets should have you depart from Ghana on September 15th 2026, and arrive back in the United States on September 16th 2026.

Your tour begins when you arrive in Ethiopia on September 6th and ends when we see you off at the airport on September 15th 2026.

Ethiopia Travel Requirements

Ethiopia is a tourist friendly destination, but it is important that you are aware of travel requirements and have your travel documents ready well in advance of your departure date. Please read the following information carefully.

Passports and Visas

A valid passport is required for all international travel.

U.S. citizens need a visa to enter Ethiopia for stays of up to 30 days. However, there are other requirements to meet, including:

Passport: A valid U.S. passport with at least one blank visa page

Proof of travel: Proof of return or onward flights

Proof of funds: Proof of sufficient funds for the duration of your stay

Proof of purpose: Documents showing the purpose of your trip

Visa Fee: \$62

Your passport must be valid for at least six months from the date of your arrival back in the United States. Check your passport expiration date to be sure it meets this requirement and if necessary, apply for a renewal as soon as possible. You will not be allowed to board your departure flight if your passport expiration date is within six months of your scheduled return to your home country.

Immunization and Medical Information

Yellow Fever Vaccination:

Yellow fever vaccination is not required of US citizens who have not been in an infested area.

If you get the Yellow Fever vaccine, be sure this is indicated in your yellow International Certificate of Vaccination or Prophylaxis (ICVP). **It is your responsibility to comply with all immunization requirements.**

Malaria Prevention and other Immunizations:

Your doctor might also recommend other vaccinations which are not mandatory for travel to Ethiopia. It is up to you to decide if you take any or all such recommended vaccinations as they are not required for entry into Ethiopia.

While it is not mandatory, we strongly recommend that you acquire anti-malarial medication. Malaria is a serious potential (but treatable) health threat, and you should take necessary precautions to minimize your risk.

It is also a good idea to bring your favorite mosquito repellent to further protect yourself from the mosquitos that you might encounter.

Prescription Medications:

If you take prescription medication, you are responsible for determining their legality in Ethiopia and note the following:

- We advise you to bring enough of your medication with you.
- Always keep your medication in the original container.
- Carry a copy of your prescription(s).
- Pack your medicine in your carry-on luggage, not your checked luggage.

Travel Insurance

Travel Insurance is not included in your package. However, it is strongly recommended that you purchase travel insurance to cover any unexpected event that might interrupt or prevent your travel.

Our company offers optional travel insurance through Allianz Global, a leader in the travel insurance field. You can click on the link below or go to our website www.africanconnections-usa.com to get a quote.

<https://www.agentmaxonline.com/agentmaxweb/widgets/quotetool.html?widgetid=859099&accam=F212819&code=ABIYU4TLWGBGTNHC6ZWLRSKAR65GB6C5JLBJOIXR7QY3M6I5HDDHZDIECAM4JHS6KBOBIU5FYWBJM3BAHKTF TOR572B73AM4ZH74ZMNXVK3YLBWT3Z3F4X4R3Z53LEU4>

Shopping in Ethiopia

You'll love shopping in Ethiopia! From the lively markets of Addis Ababa to the historic towns of Lalibela and Gondar, Ethiopia offers a vibrant and authentic shopping experience steeped in ancient tradition and craftsmanship. Discover the soft elegance of shemma cloth, handwoven into beautiful scarves and habesha kemis dresses, the dazzling silver and brass crosses from the

highlands, and the intricate designs of hand-carved wood and leather goods. Explore colorful basketry from the Sidama and Oromo regions, striking Harari wall hangings, and the rich aroma of Ethiopian coffee beans—perfectly packaged to take a piece of the country’s coffee heritage home. Whether you’re bargaining at Merkato, Africa’s largest open-air market, or browsing artisan workshops in small villages, you’ll find an array of handmade treasures and unique souvenirs that reflect Ethiopia’s rich cultural mosaic and timeless artistry.

Clothing and Packing

Bring comfortable, breathable clothing for your trip to Ethiopia. Lightweight fabrics like cotton and linen are ideal for the warm, sunny days, especially if you’ll be visiting the lowland areas such as the Omo Valley or the Danakil Depression. However, Ethiopia’s highland cities like Addis Ababa, Lalibela, and Gondar sit at higher elevations, where mornings and evenings can be cool—so pack a light sweater or jacket to stay comfortable. Sturdy walking shoes are a must, especially if you plan to explore historic sites, trek in the Simien Mountains, or wander through bustling markets.

Note: Ethiopia is a country with deep cultural traditions and strong religious heritage, particularly in Orthodox Christian and Muslim communities. Modest dress is expected and appreciated, especially when visiting churches, monasteries, mosques, and rural villages. Women should consider wearing skirts or pants that cover the knees and tops that cover the shoulders, while men are encouraged to dress conservatively in these settings. If you plan to attend a religious festival or visit rock-hewn churches like those in Lalibela, women may be asked to cover their heads with a scarf. A wide-brimmed hat, sunglasses, and sunscreen will help protect you from the strong highland sun, and don’t forget your swimsuit if you plan to relax in the natural hot springs of Sodere or Wondo Genet.

Don’t bring electrical appliances and gadgets. The electric outlets in Kenya are 240 volts, while U.S. appliances are 110 volts. **This means you will not be able to use your U.S. small appliances and devices in Kenya.** The exceptions are laptops, phone chargers and other such devices which are usually universal and should work in Kenya. You might need an adapter for these devices, however, as the outlets in Kenya are a different shape than those common in the U.S.

You can bring your own adapter or buy one when you arrive as adapters are very inexpensive in Benin and are readily available.

Toiletries/Personal Items

Be sure you bring all your toiletries and personal items. While you will have opportunities to buy such things in Kenya, you might not be able to find the brands you prefer.

Customs Requirements

Passengers' obligations at Ethiopian Customs are outlined on the Ethiopian Customs Commission (ECC) website. For full details, please visit <http://ecc.gov.et/web/ecc/ecc>

When you arrive in Ethiopia you will pass through Ethiopia Customs, and you might be asked if you have anything to declare. You must declare any commercial goods or currency more than \$3,000 that you bring into Ethiopia.

Money/Credit and Debit Cards/ATM's:

Cash

There is no limit on the amount of money you can bring into Ethiopia. However, as stated above, if you bring in more than \$3,000 in cash, you must declare it when you pass through customs on entry. If you bring in less than \$3,000, there is no need to declare any cash that you bring in.

You will have several opportunities to change your dollars for the local currency during your stay in Ethiopia. Please note that it is advisable that you bring any cash that you bring in either \$100 or \$50 bills as smaller denominations will be exchanged for a significantly lower exchange rate.

ATMs

There are ATMs in all the major cities you visit, but you will pay an international fee and a local bank fee for ATM transactions in addition to possibly receiving a lower exchange rate for each transaction.

Credit and Debit Cards

There will be several places where you can use your credit or debit card in Ethiopia, particularly in major hotels, international restaurants, and larger shops or supermarkets in cities like Addis Ababa, Bahir Dar, and Mekelle. However, Ethiopia remains largely a cash-based economy, especially in rural areas, local markets, and smaller businesses. It's a good idea to carry enough Ethiopian birr for everyday purchases and tipping. If you plan to use your debit or credit card while traveling, be sure to notify your bank in advance that you will be in Ethiopia to avoid any security holds or transaction blocks on your account.

Also, note, many of the businesses that take debit or credit cards use POS equipment which requires a pin number. While we all know our debit card pin number, most of us do not have or know a pin number for our credit cards. So, if you intend to use a credit card, contact your bank, and make sure you have and know the pin number associated with the card.

Note: the only credit cards accepted in Kenya are Visa and Mastercard.

Food and Water

Your tour package includes breakfast daily and other specified meals (lunch/dinner), including a Welcome Dinner with Cultural Performances.

You will be able to buy meals that are not included in the tour package at restaurants that we have carefully selected. There will be a wide variety of food options available, giving you the chance to enjoy delicious Ethiopian cuisine, while also having access to more familiar international dishes. From flavorful injera (sourdough flatbread) served with spicy wot stews and savory tibs (sautéed meat) to fresh vegetables, lentil dishes, and aromatic Ethiopian coffee, there's something to suit every palate. The average cost of a meal with a soft drink and water in Ethiopia ranges from \$10–\$20, depending on the location and type of restaurant.

Bottled water is readily available. However, the water in all of the hotels and restaurants that have been selected for you is potable and is safe for you to use as ice cubes or to brush your teeth. While some of your favorite snacks might be available in Kenya, and we will make regular stops for you to stock up on snacks, fruit, and drinks during the trip, it is advisable for you to bring the special snacks that you prefer.

Hotels and Restaurants in Ethiopia:

Hotels

You will be staying at hotels that have been carefully selected for you to ensure your comfort. These hotels are highly rated with clean comfortable rooms and well-trained staff. However, standards might vary from those to which you might be accustomed. For example, while bath towels and hand towels are available and supplied at all the selected hotels, face cloths are not normally available. So, you should bring your own face cloth. Rest assured; our ground staff will be available to address any issue that might arise.

Restaurants

We have carefully selected each of the restaurants you will visit on your tour. These restaurants are chosen for their quality, cleanliness, and welcoming atmosphere, offering you a chance to enjoy safe, wholesome meals throughout your stay. You'll have the option to try authentic Ethiopian dishes or choose from a variety of continental options that may be more familiar to your taste.

While the food is tasty, Ethiopian restaurants are known for slow service, so you might have to exercise a bit of patience before your meal arrives. Whenever possible, our staff will help you to place your order in advance of arrival at a restaurant, to cut down on the wait time.

Cell Phone/Data Usage and Internet Service:

Before your departure to Ethiopia contact your mobile phone service provider and request international data service to access WhatsApp, or similar apps for internet-based communications. Such communications are significantly less costly than international roaming charges. You could also ask for a one-month international voice package. While this could be costly, it is cheaper than the bill you will receive if you make calls without a call package.

If you make or receive international calls while you are in Ethiopia and you do not have the appropriate international call/data packages, you will be shocked when you receive your telephone service billing statement.

Other information that might be helpful as you prepare for your trip:

Country Profile

Ethiopia is located in the Horn of Africa, bordered by Eritrea to the north, Djibouti and Somalia to the east, Kenya to the south, South Sudan to the west, and Sudan to the northwest. The country's diverse geography includes the towering Ethiopian Highlands, the Great Rift Valley, fertile plateaus, and the low-lying Danakil Depression—one of the hottest and most geologically active places on Earth. Ethiopia is also home to Lake Tana, the source of the Blue Nile River, and Ras Dashen, the highest peak in the Simien Mountains. The climate varies significantly: the highland areas enjoy a cooler, temperate climate, while the lowland regions are hot and arid. Ethiopia experiences two rainy seasons: the belg (short rains) from March to May and the kiremt (long rains) from June to September.

The capital city is Addis Ababa, a political and diplomatic hub that hosts the headquarters of the African Union. Other important cities include Gondar, known for its castles and royal history; Bahir Dar on Lake Tana; Mekelle in the Tigray region; and Hawassa in the Great Rift Valley. Ethiopia has a population of over 120 million people, making it the second-most populous country in Africa. It is home to more than 80 ethnic groups, with the Oromo, Amhara, Somali, and Tigray being the largest. Amharic is the official working language, but many other languages, such as Oromo, Tigrinya, and Somali, are widely spoken. Ethiopia is religiously diverse, with Ethiopian Orthodox Christianity, Islam, and Protestant Christianity as the major faiths, alongside traditional beliefs practiced in some communities.

Ethiopia's rich history stretches back thousands of years, including the ancient Kingdom of Aksum, famed for its obelisks and early Christian heritage. It is celebrated as the only African

country never colonized, preserving a unique cultural identity. Ethiopia is also known as the birthplace of coffee, the origin of humanity with significant archaeological finds like Lucy, and a land of vibrant festivals such as Timket and Meskel. Today, Ethiopia is recognized for its historical treasures, stunning landscapes, diverse cultures, and the warmth and hospitality of its people.

Geography:

Ethiopia, officially the Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia, is located in the Horn of Africa and stretches from the highlands of the north and central plateau to the low-lying Afar and Somali regions in the east. It shares borders with Eritrea to the north, Djibouti and Somalia to the east, Kenya to the south, South Sudan to the west, and Sudan to the northwest. Though landlocked, Ethiopia maintains access to key regional trade routes through agreements with neighboring ports, particularly in Djibouti.

Covering approximately 1,104,300 square kilometers (426,400 sq mi), Ethiopia is the largest country in the Horn of Africa and the second-most populous nation in Africa, with over 120 million people. It is celebrated for its extraordinary cultural and ethnic diversity, home to more than 80 distinct ethnic groups and a wide array of languages. Ethiopia is a federal parliamentary republic, organized into ethnically based regional states. It is unique in Africa for maintaining its sovereignty during the colonial era, with only a brief Italian occupation in the 1930s. Ethiopia has played a central role in African politics and diplomacy, hosting the headquarters of the African Union in its capital, Addis Ababa. Despite facing various developmental and political challenges, Ethiopia has preserved a strong sense of historical identity and pride. It remains a key player in the stability, heritage, and development of the Horn of Africa and the wider continent.

Economy:

The economy of Ethiopia is diverse and rapidly evolving, with key sectors including agriculture, services, manufacturing, construction, and energy. Agriculture remains the backbone of the economy, employing the majority of the population and contributing significantly to GDP. Major crops include coffee—Ethiopia is considered the birthplace of coffee and remains one of the world's top exporters—alongside oilseeds, pulses, cereals like teff and maize, and horticultural products such as flowers and vegetables. Ethiopia is also rich in natural resources, with deposits of gold, tantalum, potash, and gemstones. The mining sector is expanding steadily, alongside significant investments in hydroelectric power, making Ethiopia one of Africa's leading producers of renewable energy through projects like the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam (GERD). Tourism is an important and growing sector, with Ethiopia globally recognized for its ancient historical sites, including the rock-hewn churches of Lalibela, the castles of Gondar, the Simien Mountains, and the unique cultural traditions of the Omo Valley tribes.

The country has made substantial progress in infrastructure development, particularly in road construction, energy production, and industrial parks aimed at boosting exports. Addis Ababa, the capital and commercial hub, also serves as a key diplomatic center for Africa. In recent years, the government has prioritized industrialization, expanding manufacturing through its Growth and Transformation Plans (GTP), and strengthening sectors like textiles, leather, and agro-processing. Ethiopia's vision is to transform into a middle-income, manufacturing-driven economy while continuing to develop its human capital and regional trade ties.

Currency:

The official currency of Ethiopia is the Ethiopian Birr, with the currency code ETB. It is commonly represented as "Br" or simply "Birr." The Ethiopian Birr is not pegged to any foreign currency, and its exchange rate with the U.S. dollar may vary based on market conditions. When traveling to Ethiopia, you can exchange U.S. dollars for Ethiopian Birr at local banks, authorized currency exchange bureaus, or at the airport. It is advisable to carry some Ethiopian Birr for everyday purchases, as U.S. dollars are generally not accepted for regular transactions, especially outside major cities. Regarding bringing cash into the country, travelers can bring up to 1,000 Ethiopian Birr in local currency. For foreign currency, if you are carrying the equivalent of \$3,000 USD or more, you must declare it to customs upon arrival. Amounts below this threshold do not require a declaration. Always keep your currency declaration form, as it will be required when exchanging money or upon departure.

Language:

The official working language of Ethiopia is Amharic, which plays an important role in the country's governance, education, and business sectors. Amharic is the federal government's primary language and is widely spoken across many regions, serving as a key medium of communication among Ethiopia's diverse ethnic groups. In addition to Amharic, Ethiopia recognizes many regional languages as official within their respective federal states. Oromo, Tigrinya, Somali, Afar, Sidamo, and Wolaytta are among the most widely spoken indigenous languages, each predominant in its own region and commonly used in homes, local schools, and community affairs. Ethiopia is one of the most linguistically diverse countries in Africa, home to more than 80 distinct ethnic groups and over 80 languages belonging mainly to the Cushitic, Semitic, Omotic, and Nilo-Saharan language families. English, introduced as a foreign language, is commonly used in secondary schools, universities, and in certain business and government contexts, especially in Addis Ababa and other major cities.

In urban areas like Addis Ababa, Dire Dawa, and Bahir Dar, Amharic is widely spoken, and many people, particularly in the hospitality and service sectors, have a good command of English. In rural areas, local ethnic languages are more dominant in daily life, although people often

understand Amharic to some extent, especially for official matters. For visitors, communication is generally manageable in cities and tourist destinations, where English is understood. However, learning a few basic phrases in Amharic (such as Selam for hello and Amesegenallo for thank you) or the local language of the region you are visiting can greatly enhance your interactions and is warmly appreciated by locals.

Government:

The Constitution of Ethiopia was adopted in 1995, establishing a federal parliamentary republic with a government structured around three main branches: the Executive, Legislative, and Judiciary. Ethiopia's political system is guided by principles of federalism, separation of powers, and the rule of law, with special emphasis on the rights of its diverse ethnic groups.

The country is divided into 11 regional states (kililoch) and two chartered cities (Addis Ababa and Dire Dawa). These regions are largely based on ethnic lines and have significant autonomy, including the right to self-administration. Ethiopia's Parliament consists of the House of Peoples' Representatives and the House of Federation. The Prime Minister is the head of government and exercises executive power, while the President serves as the ceremonial head of state. General elections are held every five years.

Current President: His Excellency Taye Atske Selassie

History:

Before European colonization, Ethiopia was home to a wide range of ancient civilizations, kingdoms, and ethnic communities, each with its own systems of governance, culture, and trade. Notable among these were the Aksumite Empire, the Zagwe dynasty, the Solomonic dynasty, and the Oromo, Sidama, Afar, and Somali peoples, among many others. Ethiopia's highlands became a center of early Christianity in Africa, while the lowland areas maintained Islamic and indigenous belief systems. The ancient city of Aksum was a powerful trading empire from the 1st to 7th centuries, engaging in commerce with the Roman Empire, Arabia, India, and beyond. Ethiopia's Red Sea port of Adulis made it an important player in regional trade in gold, ivory, frankincense, and slaves. Unlike most African countries, Ethiopia successfully resisted European colonization. The Battle of Adwa in 1896 marked a defining moment when Emperor Menelik II defeated Italian forces, preserving Ethiopia's sovereignty. This victory made Ethiopia a symbol of African independence and pride across the continent. However, in 1935, Fascist Italy under Mussolini invaded and occupied Ethiopia, establishing Italian East Africa. This occupation lasted until 1941, when Ethiopian forces, supported by British allies, successfully expelled the Italians, and Emperor Haile Selassie was restored to power.

Throughout the 20th century, Ethiopia underwent significant political and social transformations. In 1974, a military coup known as the Derg overthrew Emperor Haile Selassie, ending the monarchy and establishing a Marxist-Leninist regime. The Derg period was marked by land reforms but also widespread human rights abuses, political repression, and a devastating famine in the 1980s that drew global attention. Armed resistance movements, particularly the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF) and the Eritrean People's Liberation Front (EPLF), eventually overthrew the Derg in 1991. Following the fall of the Derg, Ethiopia adopted a federal system based on ethnic lines under the Ethiopian People's Revolutionary Democratic Front (EPRDF). Eritrea, which had been annexed by Ethiopia, gained independence in 1993. Ethiopia's new constitution in 1995 introduced ethnic federalism, granting regions the right to self-administration and even secession. This system brought both increased local autonomy and ongoing ethnic tensions. In recent years, political changes accelerated with the rise of Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed in 2018, who introduced reforms, released political prisoners, and signed a peace deal with Eritrea, earning him the 2019 Nobel Peace Prize. However, the country has also faced renewed conflict, most notably the Tigray War (2020–2022), which caused a humanitarian crisis and international concern. Today, Ethiopia remains one of Africa's oldest and most historically significant nations, playing a central role in continental diplomacy as the headquarters of the African Union. Despite challenges related to ethnic federalism, political instability, and development disparities, Ethiopia continues to be a cultural, historical, and geopolitical powerhouse in the Horn of Africa.

Climate:

Ethiopia has a varied highland and lowland climate, shaped by its diverse topography and elevation. The Ethiopian Highlands, including the capital Addis Ababa and cities like Bahir Dar and Lalibela, enjoy a temperate climate year-round thanks to their elevation—often called "the land of eternal spring." In contrast, the lowland regions, such as the Afar Depression, Gambella, and parts of the Ogaden in the east, experience hotter and drier conditions. The western and southern regions, near the borders with Sudan and South Sudan, tend to be wetter and more tropical. Average daily temperatures in Ethiopia range from about 60°F to 86°F (16°C to 30°C), depending on the altitude and season. Addis Ababa, situated at about 7,700 feet (2,355 meters) above sea level, typically enjoys mild temperatures, with average highs around 70°F (21°C). Ethiopia has two main rainy seasons: the kiremt (long rains) from June to September and the belg (short rains) from March to May. The main dry season, known as bega, runs from October to February, bringing cooler and sunnier weather to much of the country.

In September, Ethiopia is at the tail end of its long rainy season, especially in the highlands. Rainfall starts to taper off as the month progresses, particularly in central and northern areas like Addis Ababa, Axum, and Gondar. Daytime temperatures remain mild in the highlands, averaging between 68°F and 77°F (20°C to 25°C), while nights can be cool, dropping to around 50°F (10°C).

In the lowlands, it's warmer and more humid, with temperatures reaching up to 86°F (30°C). September also marks the start of clearer skies and the gradual return of dry, sunny weather, making late September an increasingly popular time for visitors. Additionally, September is culturally significant, as Ethiopia celebrates Enkutatash (the Ethiopian New Year), bringing festive events and bright green landscapes after the rains—an especially beautiful time for sightseeing and photography.

Frequently Asked Questions

General Travel Information

1. Do I need a visa to visit Ethiopia?

Yes, U.S. citizens need visa to visit Togo for up to 90 days. Your passport must be valid for at least six months beyond your departure date and have at least one blank page for entry stamps.

2. How can I apply for a Ethiopian Visa?

You can apply for a visa online via the Ethiopia e-Visa Portal or upon arrival at Ethiopia Airport with entry visas cost of \$62. Check our website for the latest visa information and application links.

3. What vaccinations do I need before traveling?

A Yellow Fever vaccination is required for entry into Ethiopia. Other recommended vaccines include Hepatitis A & B, typhoid, tetanus, and malaria prophylaxis.

4. Is Ethiopia safe for tourists?

Ethiopia is generally considered safe for travelers, particularly in well-visited areas such as Addis Ababa, Lalibela, Gondar, Bahir Dar, Axum, and national parks like the Simien Mountains and the Bale Mountains. However, as with travel to any country, it's important to remain vigilant and take standard precautions. Petty crime—such as pickpocketing, bag snatching, and phone theft—can occur, especially in crowded areas like markets, public squares, and transport hubs in Addis Ababa and other large cities. Travelers are advised to avoid walking alone at night, especially in dimly lit or unfamiliar neighborhoods. It's also

wise to limit the cash and valuables you carry and store important documents, such as passports, in your hotel safe whenever possible.

When moving around cities, using registered taxis or reputable ride-hailing apps (such as Ride or Feres in Addis Ababa) is generally safer than informal taxis or public minibuses, particularly after dark. Tourist sites and rural destinations, including the historical circuit in the north and national parks, are typically safe and welcoming, with local communities often showing warm hospitality to visitors. That said, travelers should always heed local advice, stay on well-trodden paths, and consider hiring licensed guides when exploring remote areas. While most trips to Ethiopia are trouble-free, it is important to stay updated on local travel advisories, especially concerning regions like Tigray, border areas near Somalia, South Sudan, and parts of Oromia and Amhara, where security conditions can sometimes be unpredictable. As with any destination, showing respect for Ethiopia's rich traditions and local customs, maintaining situational awareness, and staying informed about the latest developments will help ensure a safe and enriching experience in the country.

5. What is the best time to visit Kenya?

September is a great time to visit Ethiopia. In September, Ethiopia is at the tail end of its long rainy season, especially in the highlands. Rainfall starts to taper off as the month progresses, particularly in central and northern areas like Addis Ababa, Axum, and Gondar. Daytime temperatures remain mild in the highlands, averaging between 68°F and 77°F (20°C to 25°C), while nights can be cool, dropping to around 50°F (10°C). In the lowlands, it's warmer and more humid, with temperatures reaching up to 86°F (30°C). September also marks the start of clearer skies and the gradual return of dry, sunny weather, making late September an increasingly popular time for visitors. Additionally, September is culturally significant, as Ethiopia celebrates Enkutatash (the Ethiopian New Year), bringing festive events and bright green landscapes after the rains—an especially beautiful time for sightseeing and photography.

6. What is the dress code in Kenya?

Bring comfortable, breathable clothing for your trip to Ethiopia. Lightweight fabrics like cotton and linen are ideal, especially for the generally warm and sunny conditions in lower-altitude areas such as Addis Ababa, Bahir Dar, and the Great Rift Valley. However, much of Ethiopia lies at higher elevations, including popular destinations like Lalibela, Gondar, and the Simien Mountains, where mornings and evenings can be quite cool—even in the dry season (like in September). It's advisable to pack a light sweater or jacket for these cooler temperatures, as well as layers you can add or remove throughout the day.

7. **Are public toilets available at tourist sites?**

Public toilets are available at major tourist attractions, but they may not always be well-maintained. Carry tissues and hand sanitizer.

8. **Is there internet access?**

Hotels, cafes, and restaurants in major cities offer Wi-Fi. A local SIM card is recommended for better mobile internet access.

9. **Is it allowed to take photographs of people?**

Always ask for permission before photographing individuals, especially in rural areas and markets.

10. **What fitness level is required for sightseeing?**

A moderate fitness level is recommended, especially for excursions to natural sites and islands.

11. **What kind of shoes should I wear?**

Comfortable walking shoes or sandals are essential for your trip to Ethiopia, especially if you plan to explore historic sites, bustling markets, or take part in outdoor excursions. Closed-toe shoes with good support are highly recommended for activities like visiting the rock-hewn churches of Lalibela, trekking in the Simien Mountains, or touring archaeological sites in Axum, where uneven terrain and cobblestone paths are common. Sturdy, lightweight hiking shoes or trainers are ideal for these kinds of adventures, providing both comfort and protection from dust and rough surfaces. For casual strolls in warm, lower-altitude cities like Bahir Dar or Awash, breathable sandals can be a comfortable option. Regardless of your itinerary, shoes that can handle both urban and rural conditions will serve you well in Ethiopia.

12. **How is the power supply in Ethiopia?**

The electric outlets in Ethiopia supply 220 volts at a frequency of 50 Hz, which is higher than the 110 volts used in the United States. If you're traveling from the U.S. or another country with a different voltage standard, be aware that appliances that are not dual voltage will require a voltage converter to operate safely in Ethiopia. Fortunately, most modern electronic devices—like smartphones, laptops, cameras, and tablets—are typically dual voltage (100–240V) and should work without issue. Always double-check the voltage label on your device before plugging it in. Ethiopia primarily uses Type C and Type E/F plugs, which have two round prongs (the same as much of continental Europe). If your device's plug is different, you will need a plug adapter. It's a good idea to bring a universal travel adapter, especially if you plan to travel to other countries in the region. A small power strip with surge protection can also be handy if you're charging multiple devices at once or staying in areas where outlets are limited.

13. **Can I drink alcohol in Ethiopia?**

Yes, alcohol is widely available in Ethiopia and is commonly served in hotels, restaurants, bars, and clubs, especially in major cities like Addis Ababa, Dire Dawa, Bahir Dar, and popular tourist destinations such as Lalibela, Gondar, and the Simien Mountains. Ethiopia has a predominantly Christian population, particularly in the Ethiopian Orthodox Church, and alcohol is generally accepted and enjoyed as part of social and cultural gatherings. Traditional Ethiopian drinks such as tej (a honey wine) and tella (a local beer) are also popular and offer visitors a chance to experience unique local flavors.

However, in areas with a significant Muslim population, such as parts of the Afar and Somali regions or in the city of Harar, alcohol may be less prominently available, and public consumption is more discreet out of respect for Islamic customs. That said, many hotels and lodges in these areas still serve alcohol to guests. As with any destination, visitors are encouraged to drink responsibly and be mindful of local customs, especially during religious observances like Ramadan. Respecting the cultural environment and the people will help ensure a pleasant and welcoming experience in Ethiopia.

14. **Is smoking allowed in Ethiopia?**

Smoking is permitted in outdoor areas in Ethiopia, but it is prohibited in enclosed public spaces, including restaurants, bars, offices, airports, and on public transportation. The Ethiopian government has established smoking regulations aimed at protecting public health, especially in cities like Addis Ababa and other major towns. Designated smoking areas are sometimes provided in larger establishments such as hotels, shopping malls, and airports, though they may not always be clearly marked.

Smokers should be aware that violating smoking restrictions in public places can lead to fines or other penalties. It's advisable to look for signs or ask staff before lighting up, particularly in urban areas and more formal settings. As always, being considerate of non-smokers and following local regulations will help ensure a smooth and respectful experience during your stay in Ethiopia.

15. **What food options are available in Ethiopia?**

In hotels throughout Ethiopia, a full buffet breakfast is commonly offered each day, typically featuring a mix of continental items and local Ethiopian favorites. Ethiopian cuisine is renowned for its bold flavors, unique spices, and communal dining style, deeply rooted in the country's ancient traditions and diverse ethnic heritage. The staple of most Ethiopian meals is injera—a large, sourdough flatbread made from teff flour—which serves both as a plate and a utensil to scoop up stews and vegetables.

Traditional Ethiopian dishes often include wats (spicy stews) made with beef, chicken, lamb, lentils, or chickpeas, seasoned with the signature berbere spice blend. A national favorite is doro wat (spicy chicken stew with boiled eggs), typically served during special occasions. Vegetarian and vegan dishes are widely available and popular, especially during fasting days observed by the Ethiopian Orthodox Church. These include options like shiro (spiced chickpea stew), atkilt wot (cabbage, carrots, and potatoes), and misir wot (spicy red lentils). In Addis Ababa and other urban centers, you'll also find Italian influences such as pasta and pizza, a legacy of Italy's brief occupation in the 1930s. Breakfast in hotels often includes fresh local fruits like papayas, bananas, and mangos, as well as fresh juices. Ethiopian coffee is world-famous, and experiencing a traditional coffee ceremony is a must. Spiced tea (known locally as shai) is also commonly served. In highland areas, barley and wheat-based dishes are more common, while lowland regions might offer specialties made from sorghum and maize.

Money & Costs

16. What currency is used in Ethiopia?

The official currency of Ethiopia is the Ethiopian Birr (ETB). Credit and debit cards are accepted in major hotels, upscale restaurants, and some larger businesses, particularly in Addis Ababa and other big cities like Bahir Dar, Gondar, and Lalibela. However, cash remains the dominant and most reliable method of payment, especially in local markets, small shops, rural areas, and even some mid-range establishments where card payment facilities may be limited or unavailable.

It's advisable to carry enough Ethiopian Birr for everyday purchases, tips, and transportation, especially when traveling outside the main urban centers. ATMs are available in cities and larger towns, and many accept international cards for cash withdrawals, though service can sometimes be inconsistent, so having backup cash is recommended. Ethiopia is still largely a cash-based economy, and mobile money systems, while growing, are not yet as widespread or integrated for international visitors as they are in some other African countries. When using cards, travelers should be mindful of possible foreign transaction fees or surcharges, and it's wise to notify your bank of your travel plans to avoid unexpected issues with card use. Also, it's best to exchange foreign currency at banks or authorized exchange bureaus, as foreign currency (like U.S. dollars) is generally not accepted for everyday transactions.

17. How much does a meal cost in Ethiopia?

A meal at a mid-range restaurant costs about \$15-\$25, while street food or casual dining can be around \$5-\$10.

18. Can I use U.S. dollars in Ethiopia?

U.S. dollars are not widely accepted. It is best to exchange money at banks or Forex Bureaus.

Transportation & Getting Around

19. Do I need an international driver's license to rent a car?

Yes, an International Driving Permit (IDP) is required to rent a car. Traffic conditions can be hectic, so hiring a driver is recommended.

20. Is public transportation safe?

Public transportation, such as minibuses and shared taxis, can be crowded and confusing. Tourists are advised to use private taxis or ride-hailing services.

Health & Safety

21. Is tap water safe to drink?

We will supply you with bottled water each day. It is also available in your hotel rooms. Although the locals all drink tap water it is very heavily chlorinated and is fine for brushing teeth and bathing, but is not recommended for drinking. The hotels and the restaurants that we select for you, all use purified water to make their ice cubes. So you should feel free to add ice cubes to your drinks.

22. Do I need travel insurance?

Yes, travel insurance is highly recommended for medical emergencies, lost luggage, and trip cancellations.

However, our company offers optional travel insurance through Allianz Global, a leader in the travel insurance field. You can click the link below or visit our website, www.africanconnections-usa.com, to get a quote.

<https://www.agentmaxonline.com/agentmaxweb/widgets/quotetool.html?widgetid=859099&ac cam=F212819&code=ABIYU4TLWGBGTNHC6ZWLRSKAR65GB6C5JLBJOIXR7QY3M6 I5HDDHZDIECAM4JHS6KBOBIU5FYWBJM3BAHKTFTOR572B73AM4ZH74ZMN XVK 3YLBWT3Z3F4X4R3Z53LEU4>

23. Should I bring my own medicine?

Bring sufficient prescribed medication for your trip. Pharmacies are available, but specific medicines may not always be in stock.

Activities

24. Is there time for shopping?

Ethiopia is celebrated for its vibrant markets, where travelers can explore a rich tapestry of traditional crafts, handmade products, and unique souvenirs that showcase the country's deep cultural heritage. Popular items to shop for include handwoven cotton scarves and shawls known as netela or gabi, intricately patterned basketry (mesob), traditional coffee sets (including jebena clay coffee pots), and colorful beaded jewelry crafted by various ethnic communities. Ethiopia is also famous for its silver and brass crosses from Lalibela and Axum, leather goods, and wooden carvings. For food lovers, Ethiopian coffee—considered some of the best in the world—is a must-buy, along with Berbere spice blends, shiro powder (chickpea stew mix), and frankincense and myrrh used in religious ceremonies. Locally produced handmade beauty products like black seed oil and shea butter are also popular.

Some of the best-known markets include Merkato in Addis Ababa—one of Africa's largest open-air markets—where you can find everything from spices and textiles to crafts and antiques. Other notable spots include Shiro Meda Market for traditional clothing, Axum's market for crosses and religious artifacts, and Lalibela's Saturday market for handicrafts and local produce. Bargaining is common and expected, and engaging in friendly negotiation is part of the Ethiopian market experience. Shopping in Ethiopia's markets not

only allows visitors to collect unique items but also helps support local artisans and preserve traditional crafts.

25. Can I make personal purchases?

Yes, budget around \$8-\$25 per day for personal expenses like snacks, drinks, and souvenirs. Larger purchases can be made with credit cards in major stores.

Prepare to be Amazed!

Beneath the majestic highlands and ancient traditions of Ethiopia lies a nation where history, spirituality, and natural beauty converge. From the rock-hewn churches of Lalibela to the origins of humanity in the Omo Valley, Ethiopia is a land of deep heritage and unforgettable wonder. Have your cameras ready!

The African Connections Team is eagerly awaiting your arrival in Ethiopia and is ready to support you as you prepare for a remarkable journey through the heart of Africa's oldest empire!